Pride, from Virtues & Values

Writing: Ahliyah Luna
Graphics: Ashley Nguyen

There is a woman housed in the corner of the MET.

The fluorescent lights hum back and forth, murmuring in monotone, vibrating against the hush of my steps. She waits within a golden frame, elongated and still, swaddled in layers that rustle in imagination. Her mouth bends in disdain, though perhaps, it is merely the shadows tightening at the edges of her lips. I lower my gaze.

Darkness sprawls across the floor, swelling with the shadows where her gown meets the light. I follow its rise, watching as fabric fades into suggestion of skin. Her form begins to blur, pale contours blooming into static clouds that gather and fold in upon themselves like wind poised to spiral.

A breathless current coils around, swindling in circles before slipping back into the earth beneath.

She pulls me closer, drawing me through each crease, torn open by every pleat, every shift in texture. My limbs vanish into the seam, sinking further below. I claw at the edge, but the embroidery latches on, threading through vessels, weaving through the lattice of bone. Twisting. Tightly binding. Piercing like teeth. Swallowing me, bit by bit. I am reduced to flesh, to fragments, each cell flickering with the tremor of my pulse. Until what remains is the sour trace of soul, exhaled from her lungs, pushed through the winding hollow of her throat, spilling like thaw into springwater.

I float—adrift, untethered—drawn by gravity's ache beyond the warmth of her hold. She absorbed me entirely: my attention, my reflexive glance. With each passing second, she grew louder in color, in cloth, in plume. Feeding off her flamboyant feathers as my skin faded into the grid of her linen, flung into realms I'll never touch.

All I can do is return—perhaps as moss clinging to the spin of a leaf on a barren tree. Or reappear as a misted fleck against the mirror she clutches, my outline refracted, stretched endlessly in loops of distortion. What remains of me is scattered, absorbed into the soil beneath her, slipping downward as neon hums overhead and the sky folds gently into dusk.

She, nonetheless, will remain. Anchored in stillness. Hoarding what can be seen. Pleading for form. Stitching all she captures into cloth, dressing absence in grandeur.